

KNOLLWOOD

A HISTORICAL TIMELINE

Knollwood & the Founding of Tennessee

Crowning Bearden Hill five miles west of downtown Knoxville, Knollwood is bound to the earliest chapters of the American Republic and the State of Tennessee through the family of its builder, Major Robert Bannon Reynolds, grandson of Revolutionary Patriot and Tennessee constitution signer Samuel Frazier.

I. THE REVOLUTION *Independence won on the frontier*

1749 *April 10* — **Samuel Frazier is born.** His records begin in Guilford County, North Carolina, where in 1771 he marries Rebecca Julian of Frederick County, Virginia.

1779 — **An oath of allegiance.** Frazier pledges his loyalty to the cause of independence, the service for which the Daughters of the American Revolution recognize him as a Patriot.

1780 *October 7* — **Battle of Kings Mountain.** Frazier serves with John Sevier and the Overmountain Men in a decisive Patriot victory that turned the tide of the war in the South.

1781 *March 15* — **Battle of Guilford Courthouse.** Frazier fights as an officer attached to General Nathanael Greene's army, in the engagement that set the stage for victory at Yorktown that October.

II. TERRITORY TO STATEHOOD *The making of the sixteenth state*

1786 — **James White builds his fort** near the confluence of the French Broad and Holston rivers. White receives the land grant that includes Bearden Hill, the future site of Knollwood.

1790 — **The Southwest Territory.** Congress organizes the Territory South of the River Ohio under Governor William Blount. That year the Frazier family relocates to Greene County, where Samuel serves as recorder of the Westfield Quaker Meeting.

1791 — **A capital is founded.** Knoxville is laid out and named for Secretary of War Henry Knox, and the Treaty of the Holston is signed at White's Fort. Blount names the town the territorial capital.

1794 — **Public service begins.** Governor Blount appoints Frazier a justice of the peace for Greene County. The same year, Blount College is chartered in Knoxville, the forerunner of the University of Tennessee.

1796 *Jan. 11 – Feb. 6* — **Tennessee's first constitution.** Elected to represent Greene County at the convention in Knoxville, Frazier is chosen for the drafting committee alongside delegates including Andrew Jackson, and becomes one of the document's fifty-five signers.

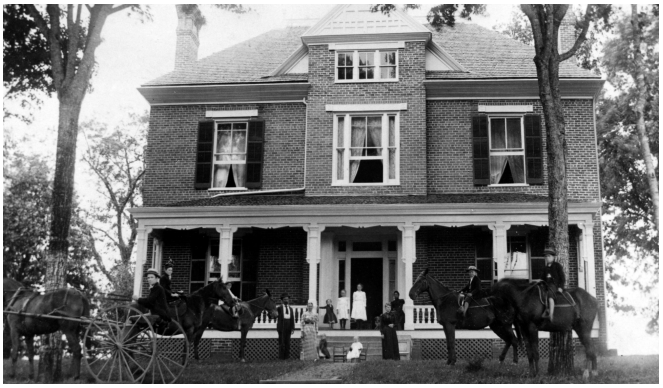
1796 *June 1* — **Tennessee becomes the sixteenth state,** with Knoxville its first capital and John Sevier its first governor. Frazier serves as Greene County's first state senator in the first three General Assemblies (1796–1801). Each Statehood Day, the original 1796 constitution bearing his signature is displayed at the Tennessee State Library and Archives.

> *"The least imperfect and most republican of the state constitutions."*
>
> THOMAS JEFFERSON, AS ATTRIBUTED, ON TENNESSEE'S CONSTITUTION OF 1796

III. BUILDING KNOLLWOOD *A family home on Bearden Hill*

1817 — **The Reynolds family arrives.** James White sells a portion of his land grant to John Reynolds, father of Knollwood's builder.

1838–1839 — **A Patriot at rest.** Rebecca and Samuel Frazier, having spent their final years on the property, are laid to rest in the Reynolds family cemetery on the hill. They were reinterred at Highland Memorial Cemetery in Bearden in 1946.



THE EDINGTON ERA *Late nineteenth century, with the Victorian porch later replaced by the columned portico.* McClung Historical Collection



AFTER 1919 *The columned portico and balustraded porch wings added by Charles Griffith, as they still stand today.*

III. BUILDING KNOLLWOOD *continued*

1846–1848 — **"The Volunteer State."** When President James K. Polk, a Tennessean, calls for 2,800 troops for the Mexican War, some 30,000 Tennesseans answer. Robert B. Reynolds accepts Polk's commission as a major.

1848–1851 — **Knollwood is built.** Reynolds sends instructions from Mexico while his sister, Rebecca, supervises construction of the Georgian-style brick home overlooking the road to Nashville. It is completed in 1851, when Knoxville counts just 2,076 residents.

1855 — **The railroad arrives.** The East Tennessee & Georgia Railroad reaches Knoxville, linking the city to national markets and ushering in decades of growth.

IV. THROUGH THE GENERATIONS *Stewards of a landmark*

1863 *Nov. 18 – Dec. 5* — **Knoxville Campaign.** General James Longstreet headquarters at Knollwood during the siege of Knoxville and the Battle of Fort Sanders. The house survives undamaged and is later returned to Reynolds by the U.S. Supreme Court.

1888 — **The Edington family.** Union Army veteran and railroad industrialist R. H. Edington makes Knollwood his home.

1903–1911 — **A legacy of public service.** Frazier's descendant James B. Frazier serves as Governor of Tennessee (1903–1905) and U.S. Senator (1905–1911).

1904–1919 — **A new century.** Bruce Keener adds the two-story kitchen wing, and in 1919 aviator and coal operator Charles Griffith, who landed aircraft on the front lawn, adds the columned front portico.

1934 — **Great Smoky Mountains National Park** is established. From 1,040 feet atop Bearden Hill, Knollwood looks toward Mount LeConte and Clingmans Dome.

1951 — **The Samuel Frazier Chapter** of the Daughters of the American Revolution is chartered in Bearden, organized by his great-granddaughter, Mrs. Andrew French Lonas.

1975 *May 12* — **National Register of Historic Places.** Knollwood is listed for its architecture and history and is marked by the Tennessee Historical Commission.

2006 *June 19* — **A gathering place for leaders.** Then-Mayor Bill Haslam, later Tennessee's 49th Governor, and Crissy Haslam host a Knox Heritage Summer Supper at the house.

V. RESTORATION *Brought back by hand*

2022 – 2026 — **A new chapter.** Knollwood Historic Preservation LLC, affiliated with Mollenhour Gross, acquires the property and begins a complete restoration. More than 300 craftsmen contribute, honored by a bronze monument near the rear entry.

2026 *October 29* — **Dedication of Historic Knollwood** with Governor Bill Lee. Opened as a gift to the East Tennessee community, the house will bear a Daughters of the American Revolution marker honoring Patriot Samuel Frazier.

Sources: NRHP nomination (1975) · NSDAR Patriot records · McClung Historical Collection